residential sales in Q3FY23 from 28 per cent in Q3FY22, the mid-level segment (Rs 50 lakh-Rs 1 crore) held steady at 36 per cent, but the share of sub-Rs 50 lakh homes (the 'lower end' of the property market) fell from 36 per cent to 29 per cent. "The underlying fabric of the market has altered significantly," the report notes, "with the mid and premium segments constituting the bulk of sales and making up for the slack in demand in the affordable segment."

Location and connectivity remain a factor in dictating consumer choice, but new buyers are also looking for improved security measures, eco-friendly power generation, water harvesting and waste management systems, parking facilities, smart home technologies such as home automation systems and voice-controlled assistants, among other things.

Experts attribute the spurt not so much to improved economic conditions as to the reduction in stamp duty in states like Maharashtra, West Bengal and Karnataka and lower interest rates on home loans during Covid. "The climbdown in home demand in the pre-Covid days was happening despite a fairly good economic improvement," says Zia Gulam, an executive director with Knight Frank. People preferred to park their money elsewhere and the economic improvement was reflected in the absorption of office space. "Then two things happened," says Gulam. "Many of the state governments began discounts on stamp duty. Mumbai saw a 60 per cent reduction in stamp duty, from 5 per cent to 2 per cent. Moreover, home loan interest rates came down to 6.3 per cent after the RBI reduced interest rates. The turnaround happened at the end of 2021. By then, India had decided that Covid is not going to matter anymore."

The stamp duty breather saw a flurry in luxury home-buying. Actor Hrithik Roshan bought two apartments on Mumbai's Juhu-Versova Link Road for Rs 97.5 crore in October 2020, a month after the Maharashtra government cut stamp duty prices. Actor Amitabh Bachchan bought a duplex apartment in Andheri for Rs 31 crore in May 2021, according to media reports. Latest data by consultants Anarock Research shows that out of 349,000 units sold in these cities in the first nine months of 2023, about 24 per cent, or 84,400 units, were homes priced above Rs 1.5 crore.

However, Abhishek Kapoor, Group CEO, Puravankara, a real estate developer, says higher home sales are across the board, not just in premium. What has increased are people's expectations. "Technology, community-building and common amenities, especially post-Covid, have become important. Buyers want to upgrade their community and living experience. They want to stay in a community that is aspirational," says Kapoor. In the premium segment, he adds, the trend is to buy larger, or second or third homes. Buyers want to own properties with the latest features for a lifetime, without having to upgrade in between. But for

Travel

Bhavna Kalyani, 40
Senior Admin at a consulting firm

Vijay Ganesh, 42
General Manager with an e-tailer

Delhi

The couple, along with their eight-year-old daughter Tashvi, take 1-2 long holidays and 8-10 small vacations every year. "We travel not only to explore new places but also to provide exposure to our daughter, who is now at an age where she will remember these new experiences," says Bhavna.





DANIEL D'SOUZA
President & Country Head-Holidays, SOTC Travel

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